The World's First Postage Stamps

Great Britain · May 1840 · Line-engraved, imperforate

1d black
Plate 1a

1d black
Plate 2

1d grey-black
Plate 6

1d black
Plate 11

The Twopence Blue · 8 May 1840

2d

2d blue
Plate 1

2d

2d deep blue
Plate 2



Rowland Hill's postal reform made a letter cost one penny anywhere in Britain, paid in advance by the sender. The Penny Black went on sale on 1 May 1840 and was valid from 6 May. Each stamp carries corner letters that show its place on the sheet of 240.

Printed by Perkins, Bacon & Petch
Portrait after William Wyon's City Medal